

ber 1987 crash. They were done in by the market's unexpected free-fall, unable in time to clear out their tremendous inventory of stocks and options or meet their margin calls.

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So stressful is the environment in which these traders operate that, on the busiest days, it is not uncommon to see traders tear up their position cards or pick up the keyboard to their Quotron (computers displaying real-time market data) and smash it into the terminal screen. I saw one guy pick up the entire unit and hurl it to the floor.

Telephones seem to be the most vulnerable to fits of pique: Not a day went by when at least five of them weren't ripped off the walls or hurled across a trading post. Things got so bad that it was rumored that New York Telephone, fed up with having to constantly replace phones, finally demanded that the Exchange buy them by the gross and do its own installation work. The Exchange now has its own army of installers out on the floor, doing triage in much the same way Army medics roam the battlefield after the fighting.

Imagine turning over the set design for the war room of the starship *USS Enterprise* to an undisciplined fourteen-year-old owner of the world's largest Erector set, whose father has cornered the market in video monitors, and you can begin to picture our working environment. An octagonal pen, off to the side of the main trading floor, the pit is actually an enclosed series of raised, rubber-matted tiers and platforms bisected by several passageways leading to the main floor of the Exchange and hopelessly cluttered with computer keyboards, monitors, time clocks, order racks, banks of tele-